



Historic win: Chasing a stiff 204, the highest total in a T20 final, against Delhi Capitals, RCB got home with two balls remaining and six wickets in hand. VIJAY SONEJI

target of 204, the highest in a WPL final. What followed under floodlights, with Georgia Voll as an able ally in a record partnership of 165, was an exhibition of jaw-dropping strokeplay from the southpaw. The revelation that she wielded the willow like a wand despite a high fever on the eve of the final only adds to her aura.

In the post-match media briefing, RCB head coach Malolan Rangarajan extolled the virtues of the star batter.

"That's the person Smriti is. When I spoke to her in the afternoon before the final, she said: 'No problem. I'll be there'. Smriti played this game with a massive flu. Not for one second did she show it," Malolan said. "She is that sort of a person who was very clear about how we wanted to play. I'm very grateful for the way she's led by example. She set

the standards in every training session."

Other than Smriti, Voll, Grace Harris and Richa Ghosh also had their moments of magic with the bat. Even Radha Yadav, who had done little since clobbering 66 against Gujarat Giants on January 16, came good in the climax with back-to-back fours to seal the deal. It is for occasions like these that the support staff, particularly batting coach R. Muralidhar, put in extensive work with the Indian all-rounder behind the scenes in the build-up to the season.

"Our batting coach worked extensively with Radha. When she came to Mumbai (before the season), we booked practice at BKC and did a lot of simulation work with her. We put her in various situations. She's also worked a lot on her power-hitting," Malolan highlighted.

It was not as if the campaign was all hunky-dory. Even before a ball was bowled, the news of ace Australian all-rounder Elysse Perry pulling out due to personal reasons would have come as a jolt. But it is a testament to the sanguine atmosphere engendered by the people who matter that Perry's replacement, Sayali Satghare, was able to step in and play her part.

Sayali took the new ball and contributed nine wickets in six matches, dovetailing nicely with spearhead Lauren Bell (12 wickets in nine matches at an economy of 5.52). The Indian medium-pacer's effectiveness also allowed RCB to bring in Voll for Linsey Smith after the first three games and bolster the batting.

According to the think-tank, the seeds for everything that unfolded during the tournament were sown last November. Once the retentions and new acquisitions were in place, RCB had the players to chart a victorious course.

"You don't win the IPL or WPL in the auction, but you certainly can lose it. So, we came to a position where we knew who we wanted to pick, we knew how we wanted to play, and we got the players who

could help us achieve that. Winning the final tonight began in November with our retentions," Malolan said.

Before RCB wrapped up its celebrations in the wee hours of February 6, Malolan was already looking ahead. "When we come back, there will be two stars on our jersey. We are chasing the third star next year," he told the players.

Given where things were a few years ago, the franchise has sure come a long way.

WPL 2026 FINAL BY THE NUMBERS

204

RCB's winning target, the highest successful chase in WPL history, also the highest chase ever in a T20 final (men or women).

165

Smriti Mandhana-Georgia Voll's second-wicket stand, the highest partnership for any wicket in WPL history.

407

Match aggregate runs, the highest in a women's T20 knockout/playoff match.

32

RCB's fours, joint-most in a WPL match.

53

Total fours in the match (RCB 32 + DC 21), the second-highest fours aggregate in WPL history.